explain the language and aggression displayed? After all, if it was only a matter of the accountability of a senior officer, then, by the same token, the commissioner of police could also have been gheraoed and harassed. There perhaps was something about Kiran's way of functioning that had raised the hackles of the lawyers. Up to 7 February 1988, they did not have anything substantial against her but somehow she had to be suspended and dismissed. This was effectively achieved by playing up the handcuffing incident to create the bogey of 'police high-handedness'.

In retrospect, one wonders whether the crime prevention activities undertaken by Kiran under the commissionerate powers entrusted to her, wherein she was holding her own courts and consolidating effective crime prevention through externment proceedings, did not provide the real reason for the lawyers' ire. After all, she seemed to have effectively curbed the role of some of the lawyers and typists as middlemen whose primary source of income was the seeking of bail for petty criminals involved in picking pockets, stealing from their own homes or those of others and delving in crimes related to their drug habits. One really wonders.

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On 22 January 1988, the lieutenant governor of Delhi, H. L. Kapur, ordered a magisterial enquiry into the entire incident. The enquiry report was to be submitted within a week.

The lawyers, however, would have nothing to do with this enquiry and continued to insist that they would not compromise on anything short of the dismissal of Kiran Bedi.

By effectively mobilizing the system of associations and unions that are so prevalent in the country, the Delhi lawyers succeeded in persuading five lakh of their colleagues all over India to join their strike. A strike of this dimension constituted a record in the history of the legal profession. Yet, the amazing fact about this bushfire strike was that it was not engendered by any noble principle or constitutional crisis but was based on a one-point programme, i.e., the dismissal of Kiran Bedi from service. And that too on the issue of the handcuffing of a person who kept changing his name and address and was caught red-handed by the students and handed over to a police officer for legal action. The main difference was that this person happened to be a lawyer too!

On 4 February 1988, the magistrate in charge of the enquiry submitted his report. He maintained that the sequence of events led him to clearly believe that Rajesh Agnihotri was definitely involved in the crime of theft and that he was rightly arrested by the police of the Roshanara Police Station. However, he held the view that Rajesh being handcuffed was not warranted.

The lawyers immediately demanded that the concerned subinspector be suspended and disciplinary action taken against him for handcuffing the accused!

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Meanwhile, a judicial enquiry had been instituted into the 21 January incident of the lathicharge on the lawyers outside the office of the DCP (N). The enquiry was to be conducted by a retired judge of the Delhi High Court, Justice P. N. Khanna. He was instructed to submit an interim report within a week and the final report within a month. But this wasn't enough for the lawyers. They wanted an enquiry to be conducted only by a sitting judge of the Delhi High Court. And eventually they had their way.

On 7 February, the lawyers of the Supreme Court called off their strike. The lawyers of the lower courts, however, were in no mood to compromise on their one-point stand, i.e., the dismissal of Kiran Bedi, before they would take any further action on the issue.

Fifteen members of the Action Committee set up by the lawyers of the Tees Hazari courts started a